

Abuse claims law gets changes

Legislation would require more proof from some who say they were victimized.

By REBECCA ELLIS AND DAKOTA SMITH

SACRAMENTO — California lawmakers said Thursday that they plan to make “modest” changes to a controversial law that gave victims of childhood sexual abuse a new window in which to sue, but will stop short of a damage cap.

The proposed legislation, offered in the final days of the legislative session, would require older victims to provide additional proof that they were abused as children, but does not limit the amount they could receive in payouts — a demand made by local governments and school districts that have shelled out billions of dollars in recent settlements.

The proposal follows years of heated debate over a 2019 state law that removed the statute of limitations for childhood sexual abuse claims. The law paved the way for thousands of victims to sue their abusers but has been criticized for draining the coffers of local governments.

Since the law was enacted, Los Angeles County has agreed to pay more than \$5 billion to settle more than 12,000 claims stemming from alleged sexual abuse committed by government employees in foster homes and juvenile halls.

Santa Monica last year declared a financial crisis after officials revealed that the city faces more than \$229 million in sexual abuse allegations claims from a former city employee. California school districts have paid nearly a half-billion dollars to settle older claims of sexual abuse.

The new bill, known as Senate Bill 577, tweaks a proposal put forward last year by Sen. John Laird (D-Santa Cruz), who tried unsuccessfully to shepherd through a compromise between local government entities, survivors groups and plaintiffs attorneys.

Laird and Sen. Tom Umberg (D-Santa Ana), who chairs the Senate Judiciary Committee, said in interviews Thursday that they tried to thread the needle in protecting both survivors and municipalities.

Laird said he’s heard reaction from various groups since the new bill proposal was posted online. The [See Law, A7]



SOME OF the hundreds of encampments without addresses scattered across north Los Angeles County.

Off grid, off on the count

The spiderweb of dirt roads etched into the desert north of Pearblossom Highway encompasses some of the trashiest scenes in Los Angeles County: piles of tires, bags of used diapers, car parts, whole burned-out cars, couches, office chairs, dining chairs, dressers, motor oil containers, dump-truck-sized mounds of unidentifiable rubble and, oddest of all, giant sheets of plastic draped over Joshua trees.

Navigating his red pickup over the rutted roads, Christopher Minsal, council president in the unincorporated community of Pearblossom, pointed out a source of the plastic: a

In the Antelope Valley, RVs make a mess of the desert — and the homeless numbers

By DOUG SMITH

distant white dome protruding from the carpet-like canopy of gray-green desert flora.

“You see the plastic in the distance?” he said. “That’s a marijuana grow.”

This downtrodden expanse of the Antelope Valley unexpectedly achieved a remarkable turnaround last year, reducing by more than half the number of recreational vehicles squatting on its back roads. At least it did so on paper.

According to the annual homeless count, only 671 recreational vehicles remained in the 400 square miles of [See RVs, A6]

A changing landscape for college degrees

A searchable database reveals graduates’ pay four years after they finish their program.

By ANDREW KHOURI

A new analysis of California data shows that four years after college graduation, students who obtain among the most competitive and in-demand bachelor degrees, mostly tied to fields in STEM — science, technology, engineering and math — are the highest-earning graduates, with salaries over \$100,000 a year.

Also among the top tier is an ultracompetitive nursing degree, which translates to an annual income of about \$125,000, according to an analysis released Friday by the HEA Group, a national education research firm. The highest-earning degree

is a combination mathematics and computer science program with an average income of nearly \$140,000.

Many humanities and social science majors — pursued by students with a passion for sociology, history, art, music and English — tend to earn far less, around \$40,000 to \$60,000, the data show.

And there is the middle rung, including business administration, urban studies and chemistry, whose graduates take home around \$70,000 on average.

The analysis comes amid a changing landscape in higher education as parents and prospective students are increasingly questioning the value of postsecondary education, evaluating how a tuition investment on a future degree will translate into a job and salary years later. Also, when it comes to borrowing money to attend [See Degrees, A7]

Educational value

Average salaries, four years after graduation, for the top three, middle three and bottom three bachelor's degrees

Highest earnings

	Average	
	\$70,851	
Mathematics and computer science	\$138,785	
Computer engineering	\$125,120	
Nursing*	\$123,693	

Near the average

Human biology	\$71,080	
Mathematics	\$70,711	
Environmental/natural resources management and policy	\$70,648	

Lowest earnings

Arts, entertainment, and media management	\$43,685	
Music	\$43,313	
Drama/theater arts and stagecraft	\$41,877	

*Registered nursing, nursing administration, nursing research and clinical nursing Data compiled using federal student loan and tax records for 180,258 bachelor’s degree graduates. Figures are a weighted average derived from median earnings. Only fields with at least 100 graduates are shown above.

The HEA Group

HAILEY WANG Los Angeles Times

An East Coast summer in L.A.

By ALEX WIGGLESWORTH AND HANNAH FRY

Southern California’s swampy summer is setting new records, with humidity levels creating conditions that feel more like Florida than the West Coast.

Forecasters attributed the punishing humidity to the remnants of Tropical Storm Iselle moving over the state, as well as unusually warm ocean temperatures due to a combination of a months-long marine heat wave, a powerful El Niño and climate change.

It’s made an intense summer of heat particularly miserable. This week saw new heat records set in some areas, but it’s the humidity that has many at their wit’s end.

Dew points in the Los Angeles Basin have been “really high,” hovering around 70 degrees in many places, with [See Humidity, A7]

Record-breaking humidity is blanketing and bewildering the Southland. What gives?



IN DOWNTOWN L.A., a man rides his bike while shading himself from intense sun and heat Tuesday.

Inflation fight takes center stage at Fed

Warsh says central bank may need to raise interest rates in the near future.

By CHRISTOPHER RUGABER

Federal Reserve Chair Kevin Warsh said Friday that inflation is still too high and suggested the central bank may have to raise interest rates in the coming months to bring it down, a clearer signal than he had sent previously about his economic outlook.

In his first high-profile speech at the Fed’s annual conference at Jackson Hole, Wyo., Warsh acknowledged that recent U.S. data show inflation has cooled a bit, but “they do not tell me that underlying trends have

A deal to trade away a piece of Yosemite

Trump administration considers swapping a parcel of the park to a private developer.

By KEVIN RECTOR

The Trump administration is considering trading a parcel of Yosemite National Park to a private commercial developer, according to administration officials, members of Congress and documents reviewed by The Times.

The proposed deal would allow the developer to build a road connecting adjacent property it already owns in Stanislaus National Forest to a service road within Yosemite, providing any future development on that property with unique access to the famed public wilderness, documents show.

According to a Friday report by the news outlet NOTUS, Trump administration officials have been quietly pressuring the National Park Service to approve the deal for the land despite such pressure being highly unusual and previous proposals for the land being repeatedly denied under the George W. Bush and Obama administrations and in court.

The Department of the Interior, which includes the National Park Service, acknowledged in a statement to The Times on Friday that a land deal is under consideration but denied any inappropriate influence from the White House.

It said negotiations for the land will comply with all federal rules for federal lands, and that “no final decisions have been made.”

An attorney for the private developer said the deal has nothing to do with politics and is in fact an “environmentally friendly” solution because it would significantly reduce the amount of driving the development’s residents would have to do to access the park.

Congressional Democrats — including Sens. Alex Padilla and Adam Schiff of California — are trying to block the deal after being informed of it earlier this year by the Land and Water Conservation Fund. The fund was created by Congress in 1964 to safeguard natural areas and public lands, and often works to acquire lands to add to national parks.

A fact sheet on the project reviewed by The Times identified the parcel by a former name, the “Hazel Green Ranch,” and said the land- [See Yosemite, A6]

Asia flood toll approaches 600

Survivors are pulled from the mud and the number saved tops 3,700. More than 2,000 are missing. **WORLD, A3**

Street vendors in political fray

How city and LAPD treat such businesses becomes a pressure point in the race for mayor. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Riley leans into pressure at USC

Coach is ready for a breakthrough in fifth season while knowing his time to deliver is shrinking. **SPORTS, B12**

Weather

Sunny and very warm. L.A. Basin: 94/71. **B3**

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